

The Blitz
Dornier Do 17Z bombers of the Luftwaffe bomb London during the Battle of Britain, 1940. The Germans' decision to strike civilian targets relieved the airfields that had been taking the brunt of the offensive, and allowed the RAF to recover.

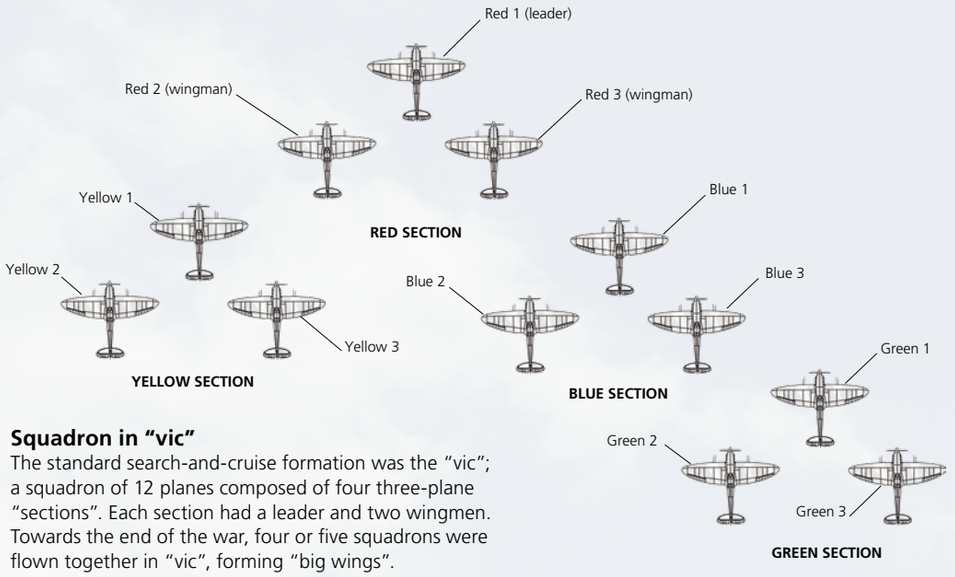
was being fought over England, they had a good chance of bailing out successfully and returning to their units unscathed. But hundreds were not so lucky. A pilot flew with an armoured plate behind his seat and a reinforced windscreen in front, but neither could provide protection against a Messerschmitt's cannon fired at close range. The worst anxiety for almost every flier was the risk of the aircraft catching fire. Pilots flew swaddled in clothing and goggles largely in the hope of finding some protection against burns if the fuel tank ignited. An unfortunate few, their faces destroyed by flames, survived to become experimental subjects for plastic surgery.

MORAL VICTORY

What kept the pilots going was partly the sheer joy in flying and fighting, the most exciting experience they would ever know. Many British fliers also bore witness to a motivating patriotism – the determination to defend their country against invaders. Pilot Douglas Bader expressed the indignation of many of his colleagues when he wrote: "Who the hell do these Huns think they are flying like this over our country in their bloody bombers covered with Iron Crosses and Swastikas?" For others, especially the Poles, there was a more savage, intimate hatred of the German enemy. Sustained by whatever belief or commitment, the RAF squadrons never faltered. Fighter Command's aim was to deny the Luftwaffe air supremacy, and in this they succeeded. The Luftwaffe was not beaten, but from October it was diverted to night bombing, an admission that it could not achieve daylight command of the air. There were around 1,900 Luftwaffe aircraft shot down in the Battle of Britain for around 1,000 RAF aircraft lost. It was by no means a clear-cut victory, but it was enough.

RAF FIGHTER TACTICS

Before the war, RAF Fighter Command trained to fly and fight in tight formations under strict control. Disciplined execution of well-drilled aerial manoeuvres was viewed as the key to success against enemy bombers. The basic formation was the "vic"; three aircraft almost wing-tip-to-wing-tip in a flat V. A squadron practised flying as four "vics", all tight to one another, and then deploying into line astern, line abreast, or some other shape for various forms of attack. When it came to combat, this formation flying proved totally unrealistic and positively harmful. Maintaining position and avoiding a midair collision absorbed attention that should have been devoted to looking for the enemy. The V-shape was hopelessly vulnerable to attack from behind. To alleviate this problem, one pilot was designated to fly behind the "vics" to guard their tails, but so many of these were shot down that the tactic had to be abandoned.

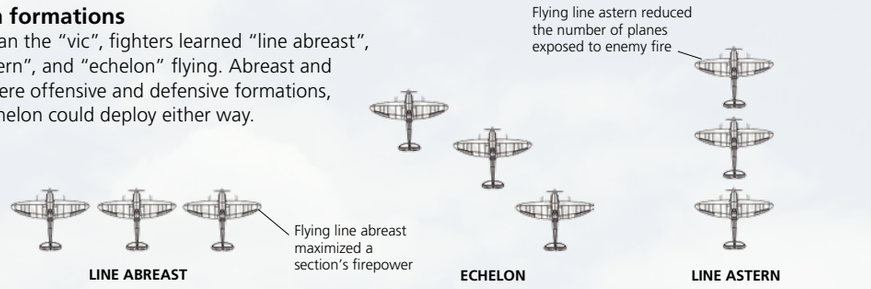


Squadron in "vic"

The standard search-and-cruise formation was the "vic"; a squadron of 12 planes composed of four three-plane "sections". Each section had a leader and two wingmen. Towards the end of the war, four or five squadrons were flown together in "vic", forming "big wings".

Section formations

Other than the "vic", fighters learned "line abreast", "line astern", and "echelon" flying. Abreast and astern were offensive and defensive formations, while echelon could deploy either way.



Battle of Britain

The Battle of Britain saw an end to the prewar tactics practised by the RAF. When German bombers appeared escorted by Messerschmitt fighter planes, the RAF Spitfires and Hurricanes were forced to break formation and engage the enemy one-on-one. This often resulted in "dogfights", with enemy fighters trying to out-turn each other.

